

SECTION NINE

TECHNOLOGY & INFRASTRUCTURE

Every romantasy is shaped by what's easy and what's hard in its world. Will your characters be able to communicate with one another when separated or will being apart for months result in no communication? Can they steal a private moment, or is someone always watching? Are wounds fatal or just a small price to pay for injury? The technology of your world answers these questions for you and these answers build the emotional structure of your entire romance.

Don't get caught up in specifics at this time. Focus on how technology shapes daily life, what it enables, and what it prevents.

> **How to Use This Section**

> Questions marked ♦ **Core** are the essentials, so answer these first to establish your world's technological foundation. The remaining questions let you go deeper into specific areas. If you're short on time, the Core questions alone will give you a working technology framework. Come back for the rest when your story needs more detail.

The Constraint Engine Principle

Technology is your story's constraint engine. Every technological decision either adds or removes an obstacle between your characters, and obstacles are what romance feeds off of. But here's the thing that makes technology constraints so powerful: they almost never function solely as obstacles. They also serve as intimacy accelerators. The same dragon bond that forces Violet and Xaden into proximity in *Fourth Wing* is also the reason they spend enough time together to move from suspicion to reluctant trust to something more. The constraint slows down the romance but at the same time fuels it.

Consider it this way. A world where characters can teleport, communicate instantly, heal any wound, and lock doors so no one can get in is a world without distance, longing, danger, and stolen moments. That's a world with very few romantic constraints. Now picture the opposite: a world where it takes weeks to travel, letters can be read by others before they arrive, a fever could kill you and the walls are thin enough to hear someone whispering. That's a world creating tension, vulnerability, and yearning on every page.

This doesn't mean low-tech is automatically better than high-tech. What it means is that every technology choice has a romantic consequence, and you should be making those choices deliberately. If you provide your characters with instant communication, you've removed the ache of waiting, so you'll need to find another source of tension. If you make healing magic simple, then you can't use injury as your constraint, so something else will have to be. The constraint engine only stalls when everything is easy. Find something that is difficult.

Technology constraints work through two mechanisms: **containment** and **conversion**. Containment is how your world manufactures unavoidable contact. Inn rooms, sleeping bags, escorted travel, shared dragon flights, carriages where there's no space to move away from each other. Conversion is how physical proximity gets translated into an emotional beat. Injury requiring touch, touch legitimising confession, shared meals revealing class difference, bathing creating vulnerability.

Effective romantasy technology choices do both simultaneously. The snowbound inn in *A Court of Mist and Fury* contains Feyre and Rhysand in the same bed while converting that closeness into confessional pacing. And the sleeping bag in *From Blood and Ash* contains Poppy and Hawke while converting body heat into erotic tension. Once you get the containment right, the conversion follows.

Your most powerful romantic technology choices will also create asymmetry: one character has some advantage over the other in terms of access to information or resources. She can send messages through enchanted mirrors; he has to wait for a letter that takes three weeks. He lives in a palace with locked doors; she sleeps in a crowded room with four other people. Think of Feyre arriving in Prythian in *A Court of Thorns and Roses*, suddenly immersed in a world of Fae magic, wealth, and technology she's never encountered, unable to read the simplest sign. This disparity between what Tamlin views as normal and what overwhelms Feyre drives their early dynamic. His world is alien, and her disorientation creates both vulnerability and resentment. The disparity between worlds creates friction, dependency, and curiosity; all the raw material romance is built from.

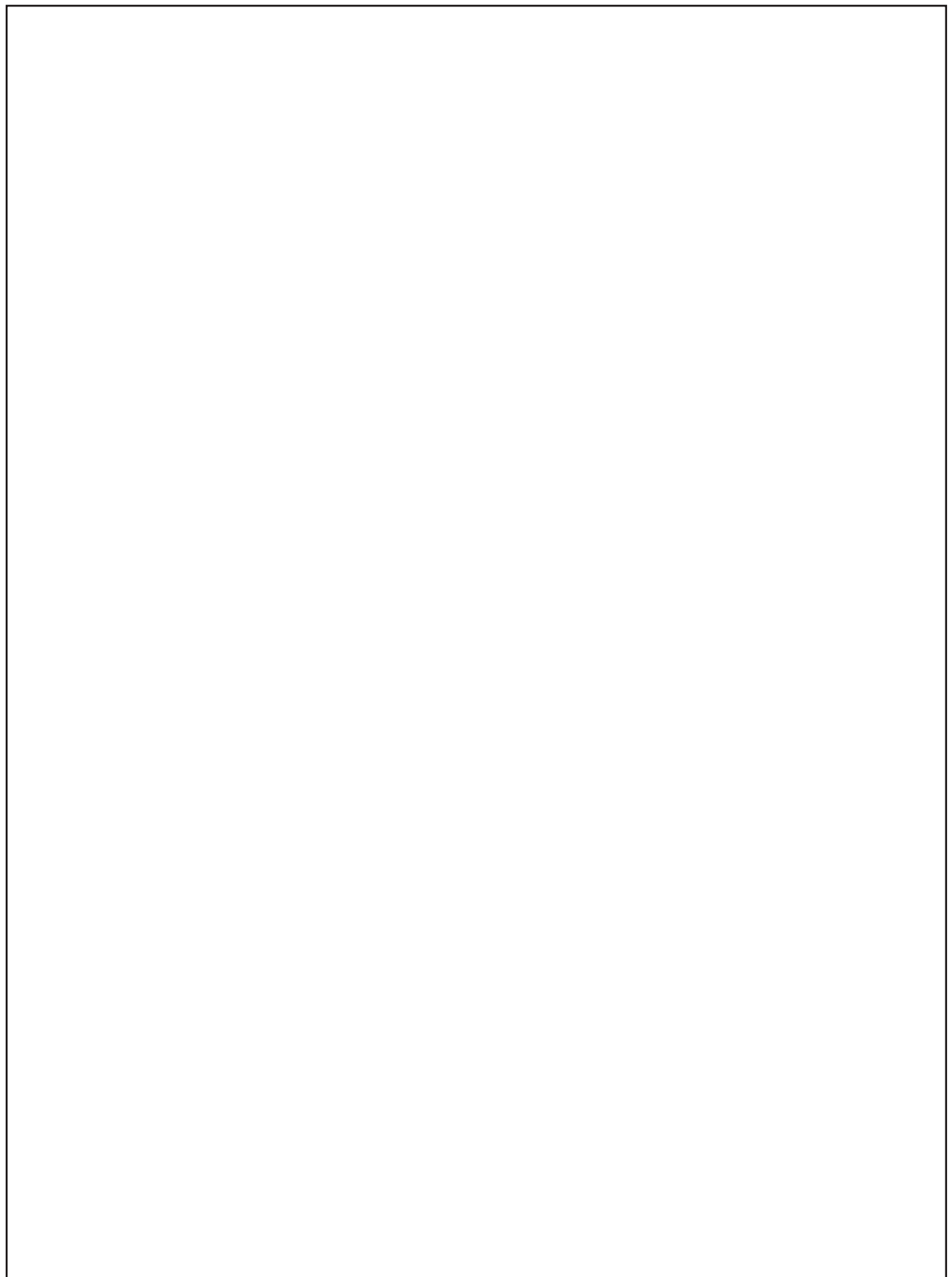
As you work through this section, keep the Constraint Engine principle in mind. Before you can map your

What feels easy in your world, and what feels hard?

Think about the basics: getting from one place to another, sending a message, staying warm, staying safe.

Which of these come easily to your characters, and which require effort, sacrifice, or luck?

(Write your answer below)



How to Think About Technology in Romantasy

Technology affects romance through five key channels. When you're building your world's tech level, think about what each choice creates:

CHANNEL	WHAT IT CONTROLS	LOW-TECH CREATES	HIGH-TECH CREATES
Distance	How hard it is to reach each other	Longing, journey-as-intimacy, painful separation	Pressure of constant access, inability to hide
Communication	How they stay connected apart	Ache of waiting, misunderstandings, treasured letters	Immediacy, nowhere to hide behind distance
Privacy	Where they can be unobserved	Stolen moments, risk of discovery, performance	Isolation, chosen vulnerability, no excuses
Vulnerability	What can hurt or kill them	High stakes, caretaking intimacy, real danger	Different stakes needed, emotional vulnerability
Identity	What can be proven or hidden	Fluid identity, secret marriages, reinvention	Accountability, inescapable pasts

Here's what these patterns look like on the page.

The strongest romantic technology constraints produce what you might call *micro-intimacy with interruption*: touch that must be hidden, words that must be delayed, care that must be given without claiming ownership. The interruption keeps the barrier intact while still feeding the relationship, which is why stolen moments under surveillance land harder than leisurely conversations in safety. If you can only touch for three seconds before someone rounds the corner, those three seconds carry the weight of an entire scene.

TECHNOLOGY CHOICE	ROMANTIC PATTERN	ROMANTASY EXAMPLE
Slow travel	Forced proximity on the road, journey romance	The snowbound inn in <i>ACOMAF</i> , one room, one bed, and nowhere to go. The sleeping bag scene in <i>From</i>

TECHNOLOGY CHOICE	ROMANTIC PATTERN	ROMANTASY EXAMPLE
		<i>Blood and Ash</i> , body heat shared out of necessity
Unreliable communication	Misunderstandings that fester, dramatic irony	In <i>Bridgerton</i> , a pregnancy letter must be physically delivered; in <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , the Maiden's communication ban turns every conversation into transgression
No privacy	Stolen moments carry enormous weight	Jude and Cardan's clandestine kiss in <i>The Cruel Prince</i> , desire that must be immediately re-contained because exposure is dangerous
Limited medicine	Caretaking as intimacy, genuine fear of loss	Hawke giving his blood to heal Poppy in <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , healing that doubles as identity revelation and changes everything
Weak documentation	Secret marriages, hidden identities	A union no one can prove, or disprove
Technology gap between characters	Dependency, wonder, shame, teaching moments	A character who's never seen running water arriving in a palace with enchanted plumbing, culture shock as romantic vulnerability

Keep these channels and patterns in mind as you work through the sections ahead. You'll return to apply them directly to your world once you've established what technology actually exists.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question in this section will apply to your world. A futuristic setting won't need to answer questions about candlelight; a pre-industrial world won't deal with mass communication. Skip what doesn't serve your story! But pay attention to the questions that make you uncomfortable or uncertain. Those are often the ones that reveal the most interesting constraints.

Quick Guide to What You Need

Every story needs: How people travel, how they communicate, and what daily life looks like.

If distance separates your characters: Focus on Movement & Distance and Communication & Connection.

If surveillance or privacy matters: Focus on Privacy & Observation.

If your characters come from different social classes: Focus on how technology access differs in Daily Life.

If you're not sure yet: Start with the Brain Dump and Overall Technology Level. You can always come back.

Common Mistakes with Technology

Mistake #1: The Convenience Trap

Magic or technology solves every problem. Instant teleportation, perfect healing, unbreakable privacy wards, flawless communication. Nothing is hard. If nothing is hard, nothing is at stake. Distance means nothing if you can teleport. Injury means nothing if healing is instant. Separation means nothing if you can talk any time. The constraint engine stalls and the romance has to generate all its tension from pure interpersonal conflict, which gets exhausting fast.

FIX

Every convenient technology needs a cost, a limit, or a gap. Teleportation works but is agonisingly painful. Healing magic can mend bones but can't cure illness. The communication spell requires rare ingredients that are running out. *Fourth Wing* does this well: wyverns give riders extraordinary power, but the bonding process kills most candidates, signets come with physical costs, and Violet's body is genuinely fragile in ways that magic can't fully fix. The convenience exists, but it's never free. Give your reader a reason to worry.

Mistake #2: The Museum Piece

Technology is described in detail (the canal system, the printing press, the enchanted forges) but never actually affects the characters or the romance. It's worldbuilding decoration. Readers don't care about your canal system unless it determines whether two characters can reach each other. Technology that doesn't create or remove obstacles is just furniture.

FIX

For every technology you describe, ask yourself: "How does this affect my characters' ability to be together, communicate, or stay safe?" If the answer is "it doesn't," cut it or rethink it.

Mistake #3: The Inconsistency Problem

Technology rules shift to serve the plot. Messages arrive in hours when the plot needs urgency, but take weeks when the plot needs separation. Healing magic works perfectly in chapter three but mysteriously fails in chapter twelve. Readers track these rules even when they don't realise it. Inconsistency breaks trust and makes the romantic obstacles feel manufactured rather than organic. **What does your world's convenience cost?**

The Convenience Trap stalls your romance when everything is easy. For every powerful or convenient technology in your world, identify what limits it, what it costs, or where it fails. If you can't find a cost, your constraint engine may be stalling. | Convenient Technology | What It Makes Easy | The Cost, Limit, or Gap | How the Cost Affects Your Romance | |—|—|—| | Wyvern bond gives riders extraordinary power (Fourth Wing) | Travel, communication, combat | Bonding kills most candidates; signets have physical costs; Violet's body is genuinely fragile | Power comes with real danger. Every flight could kill her, which keeps the stakes alive | | | | | | | | | |

| | **Technology Self-Check** Run through each technology you've described in this section. If you can't answer the first question, rethink whether you need it. If you struggle with the second, write down your rules now before inconsistency creeps in. | Technology | Does it affect your characters' ability to be together, communicate, or stay safe? (If no, cut or rethink) | What are its rules? (Write them down so they stay consistent) | |—|—|—| | | | | | | | | |

FIX

Establish your rules early. Write them down for yourself. Constraint-driven tension is strongest when the constraint has an in-world logic (dragon biology, ward physics, reputation systems, institutional rules) and when it forces decisions that reveal character under pressure. When you need the plot to go differently, change the circumstances, not the rules. The message doesn't arrive faster; the character finds a faster method and pays for it. The healing doesn't fail; the injury is of a type that healing can't fix.

Overall Technology Level

Now that you know the common pitfalls, it's time to establish what actually exists in your world. Before diving into specifics, establish the broad strokes. Your approximate technology level sets the baseline for everything that follows, and knowing where it's uneven is where the interesting story possibilities live. When your characters come from regions with different technology levels, that gap becomes a source of wonder, discomfort, and misunderstanding that fuels romantic tension.

♦ Core: What's the approximate technology level?

Reference points: Stone Age, Bronze/Iron Age, Medieval, Renaissance, Early Modern, Industrial, Modern, Futuristic, Mixed/Uneven

Is technology consistent across your world, or does it vary by region?

Technological disparity creates power imbalances and dramatic opportunities when characters cross from one level to another. A character moving from a village with no running water to a city with enchanted plumbing experiences culture shock that reveals character and creates vulnerability.

Which regions are the most advanced? Which are the least advanced? What causes the gap?

(Write your answer below)

♦ Core: What's the most advanced technology in your world, and who has access to it?

The cutting edge of your world's technology, whether it's enchanted mirrors, flying ships, or healing magic, defines your world's ceiling of possibility. More importantly, who can use it and who can't creates one of your sharpest dividing lines between characters.

(Write your answer below)

How does technology differ between cities and rural areas?

A character from a remote village arriving in a capital city may encounter technology they've never imagined. That gap between what exists in theory and what your characters have actually experienced is a rich source of wonder, disorientation, and vulnerability.

(Write your answer below)

♦ Core: How does technology differ between the wealthy and the poor?

A noble's household and a labourer's household may exist in the same city but live in different technological worlds. Identify what the richest people in your world take for granted that the poorest have never seen.

(Write your answer below)

How does magic affect technology?

The relationship between magic and technology shapes what solutions are available, and to whom. Crucially, which character has access to magical solutions and which is left relying on slower, harder, non-magical alternatives?

RELATIONSHIP	DOES THIS APPLY IN YOUR WORLD?	DETAILS
Magic replaces technology		
Magic and technology coexist		
Magic stunts technological development		

RELATIONSHIP	DOES THIS APPLY IN YOUR WORLD?	DETAILS
Magic enhances technology		

Cross-check: Does your tech level match your economic system (Section 4)? An industrial economy needs industrial technology. A subsistence economy with advanced tech needs an explanation for why that tech hasn't changed the economy.

Movement & Distance

Travel is the original romantic constraint. How much space there is between your characters and how difficult it is to get closer will determine if the time apart is merely inconvenient or agonising. Days together on the road create a completely different kind of intimacy than stepping through a portal. Sometimes the journey itself *is* the romance.

Forced proximity works by generating iterated contact under stakes: danger, surveillance, institutional rules. All of these increase the frequency of small intimacy opportunities. Shared routines, mutual observation, training, tactical decisions. In *Fourth Wing*, Rebecca Yarros made this mechanism very clear through design: because Violet's and Xaden's dragons can't be separated for more than a few days, Xaden has to go along with her travel and postings. The proximity is dictated by the biological nature of the dragons, not character choice, which means the characters can attribute their closeness to necessity rather than desire. However, even though the characters may maintain a facade of not wanting to be close, the relationship continues to grow beneath the surface.

But forced proximity doesn't always require a road. In *The Cruel Prince*, Holly Black took the mechanism of forced proximity and placed it within the confines of the court. Oaths, glamour, and political surveillance replace travel as the thing that keeps characters in each other's orbit. Jude can't leave Faerie, can't escape the court's watchful eye, can't move without being observed. The confinement isn't physical but jurisdictional, and yet the results are the same: repeated contact with the pressure of being trapped, with no way out. Think about what forces *your* characters into proximity. Is it distance? Duty? Political obligation? An unbreakable bond? The specific mechanism that brings your characters close to each other is less important than the fact that they can't walk away.

♦ **Core: What transportation methods exist?**

METHOD	SPEED	COST	WHO HAS ACCESS
On foot			
Riding animals	40–50 miles/day at easy pace	A good horse costs a year's wages for a labourer	Nobility, wealthy merchants, military; commoners walk
Vehicles (carts, carriages)			
Ships/boats			
Flying (creatures, vehicles)			
Magical transport	Instantaneous between paired mirrors	Priceless, only three working mirror-gates exist	Royal family only; using one without permission is treason

What's the fastest way to travel long distances, and what limits it?

The fastest method is often the most expensive or dangerous. Think about cost, rarity, danger, and who's allowed to use it. What would your protagonist sacrifice for speed?

(Write your answer below)

♦ **Core: How long does travel take between important locations?**

Travel time shapes the emotional weight of journeys, but don't overlook short-distance containment: a carriage ride across town can be just as powerful as a week-long journey. In Bridgerton Season 3, a single carriage scene becomes the friends-to-lovers turning point. The enclosed space, the rhythmic movement, the inability to walk away mid-conversation. The carriage functions as a sealed room on wheels.

How long does it take to travel between your world's major cities? How long is the journey your characters take?

(Write your answer below)

What short-distance travel forces your characters into close quarters?

A carriage, a small boat, a shared mount: short journeys in enclosed or cramped spaces can carry as much romantic tension as a weeks-long trek. What transport in your world creates that kind of pressurised intimacy?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes travel difficult or dangerous?

Danger on the road is one of romantasy's most reliable engines for intimacy. When characters face threats together, protection becomes care, and shared survival builds trust faster than any conversation.

What hazards do travellers face in your world?

*Think about weather and terrain, bandits or hostile creatures, cost and physical demands, and any other risks.
(Write your answer below)*

What travel infrastructure exists?

Roads, inns, and rest stops determine whether journeys are manageable or desperate. Where does infrastructure fail, and where might your characters find themselves alone, off the map, beyond observation?

What do the roads, bridges, ports, inns, and stables look like in your world?

Think about quality and coverage. Are roads paved or dirt? Are bridges reliable? How far apart are inns or way stations?

(Write your answer below)

Who builds and maintains roads, bridges, and ports?

When infrastructure breaks down, isolation follows, and isolation is where romantasy thrives. Knowing who maintains the roads and bridges tells you where they'll fail, and where your characters might find themselves stranded together.

Government? Local lords? Guilds? No one?

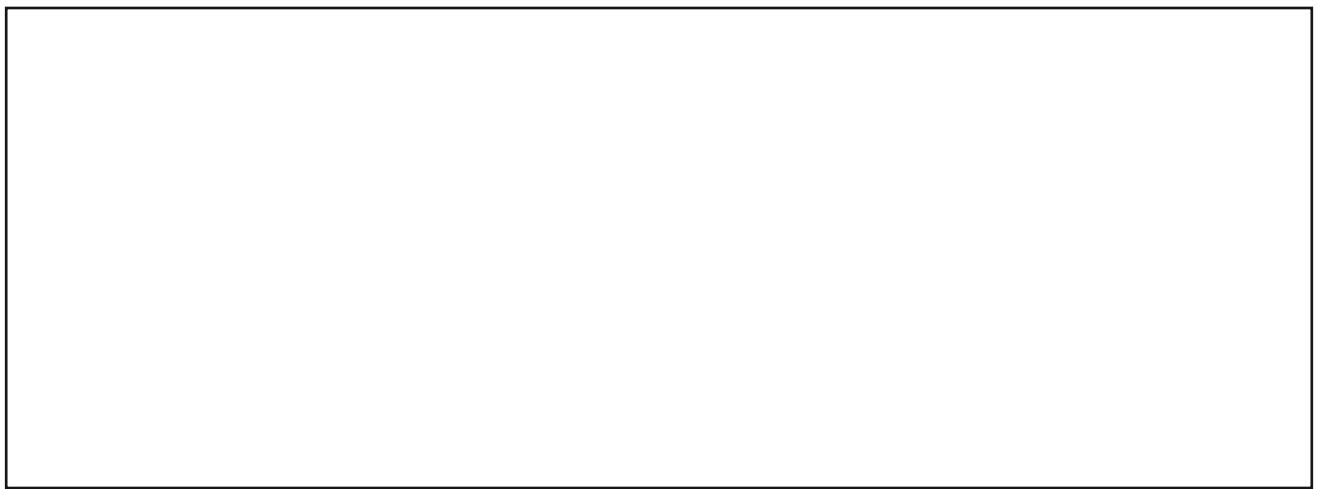
YOUR ANSWER

What happens when infrastructure breaks down?

A collapsed bridge, a flooded road, a burned way station: these failures strand characters, reroute journeys, and create the kind of isolation that forces intimacy. Knowing where your infrastructure is fragile tells you where your plot can strand your characters together.

What infrastructure is most likely to fail, and what happens when it does?

A collapsed bridge, a flooded road, a burned way station: these failures strand travellers and create isolation.
(Write your answer below)



What exists beyond the roads?

Beyond maintained infrastructure lies wilderness, danger, and freedom from observation.

What lies in the areas between settlements, away from maintained roads?

Think about terrain, wildlife, dangers, and whether anyone lives there. When might your characters venture off the map together?

YOUR ANSWER

Communication & Connection

Communication technology influences the pace at which people interact in relationships. When letters take weeks, you want to convey the ache of waiting. Reading letters over and over again until the ink begins to fade from the paper, the uncertainty of not knowing is agonising. When a message finally does arrive, slow down: recognise the handwriting, decide if you'll open it right away or wait until you can have some private time. Slow communication causes both dramatic irony (the reader knows something the character doesn't) and miscommunication that has had ample opportunity to develop into issues. Rapid magical communication produces a different type of tension: the urgency to respond as quickly as possible, the inability to utilise distance to conceal one's feelings, the intimate nature of immediate connection.

But communication constraints aren't just about speed. They also define what can and can't be said. Letters, as shown in *The Duke and I*, serve as a form of delayed emotional infrastructure. The pregnancy letter that Daphne writes to Simon must be delivered to him by her brother, and it's this slow process of delivering the letter that triggers Simon's eventual return. Lady Whistledown's gossip sheet serves as a public channel that limits what can be discussed privately. In *From Blood and Ash*, the communication restrictions are institutionalised: the Maiden's rules prohibit touch, direct speech, and even gazing upon another person. Any communication Poppy shares with Hawke is therefore a transgressive act against the rules that govern her life, and thus any exchange of basic words, such as a name, carries a great deal of weight.

Regardless of the technology, show your characters adjusting their behaviour to meet the constraints imposed by it. The use of codes in letters that may be intercepted, the frustration of having to wait for urgent news to travel, the elation of being able to speak openly for the first time.

♦ Core: What communication methods exist over distance?

Can your characters reach each other across distance, and at what cost?

METHOD	SPEED	RELIABILITY	PRIVACY
Hand-delivered letters			
Courier/postal system	3–7 days between major cities	Reasonably reliable; royal post is faster but expensive	Low, anyone can read it en route; use codes for secrets

METHOD	SPEED	RELIABILITY	PRIVACY
Messenger birds			
Signal systems (fire, flags)			
Magical communication	Instant for bonded pairs	Perfect between bonded items; requires rare enchantment	High, only the bonded holder can activate it

How long does it take to send a message between important locations?

Delayed messages create dramatic irony and miscommunication. What might change before a letter arrives?

How long does a message take between major cities? How long between your characters when they're separated?

(Write your answer below)

What happens when communication breaks down entirely?

Storms, wars, blockades, or magical interference can cut off all contact. What would your characters do if they couldn't reach each other at all, and how long before they'd assume the worst?

YOUR ANSWER

How reliable is communication?

Unreliable communication breeds misunderstanding, dramatic irony, and the ache of not knowing. A message that might never arrive carries a completely different emotional weight than one that's guaranteed.

Can messages be lost? Delayed? Intercepted? Altered?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the most secure way to send a secret message?

Secrets require secure channels. What lengths would your protagonist go to for truly private communication, and what would it cost them?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the fastest way to communicate, and what does it cost?

Urgent messages carry weight. The decision to use the fastest method signals that something matters enough to pay the price. What would justify it?

YOUR ANSWER

What workarounds do your characters use to communicate despite restrictions?

Characters who live under communication constraints develop codes, intermediaries, and stolen moments of open speech. These adaptations become part of the romance's texture. A character who has never been able to speak openly will react powerfully when they finally can.

CONSTRAINT	HOW THEY ADAPT	WHAT IT COSTS THEM EMOTIONALLY
<i>The Maiden's communication ban (From Blood and Ash)</i>	<i>Every conversation with Hawke becomes a transgressive act</i>	<i>Even speaking her own name carries enormous weight</i>

Cross-check: How does your communication technology interact with your government's ability to enforce laws (Section 5)? A government that claims tight control but has no way to intercept messages has a credibility gap. A government with magical surveillance but slow communication creates a different kind of tension.

Privacy & Observation

Privacy scarcity allows the most minor actions to have major significance, which means that as long as characters can't talk, touch, or linger around one another, every single action becomes a gesture. Show us characters that are extremely attentive to those who may overhear, watch, or come upon them at any second. Constantly waiting to hear the sound of someone walking up to their door. Whispering things that will still be heard. That sense of relief from having finally, *finally*, been able to achieve some level of privacy, but then the uncertainty as to what to do with the longed-for privacy.

Because of the court environment in *The Cruel Prince*, and the many layers of hierarchy and punishment associated with vulnerability, there are very few places in which true desires can be expressed authentically, except in secret or at the edge of secrecy. When Jude and Cardan finally kiss, Jude is taken aback by her reaction and immediately goes back into negotiating terms. Desire, even when private, has to be contained quickly, since exposure is too great a risk. In *ACOTAR Under the Mountain*, the concept of privacy doesn't exist literally: Rhysand has Feyre painted and clothed to allow him to recognise if anyone has touched her, making her entire body a space to be monitored. When Tamlin is able to touch her fingers and signal her to follow him to a private area, Rhysand is forced to use magic to remove all evidence (Tamlin's clothing is smeared with paint), in order to maintain plausible denial. This is what a character experiencing privacy scarcity looks like on paper: moments stolen, and quickly covered up, where even a single fingerprint may be lethal.

Illustrate how your characters create privacy when it's not available to them. A coded look. The conversation had in plain sight, but one that implies something much different than the actual words. A quick moment in a crowd, or behind a column. And when privacy is suddenly accessible, that shift should mean something. The door that closes, the vacant room, the space where they can finally speak freely without fear of reprisal. Privacy is more than the absence of witnesses; it's the mental shift that occurs when characters no longer have to perform.

In many historical and fantasy settings, the biggest privacy issue isn't surveillance technology. It's people. Servants, attendants, family members, and household staff see and hear everything. Their presence shapes what can be said and done, and who knows the household's secrets.

How private are domestic spaces?

The thickness of walls and the layout of rooms determine whether whispered words stay between two people or become public knowledge. Privacy at home (or the lack of it) shapes every intimate moment.

How thick are the walls? Do people have separate rooms, or share space?

HOW THICK ARE THE WALLS? DO PEOPLE HAVE SEPARATE ROOMS, OR SHARE SPACE?

Do locks exist? Who has them?

The ability to lock a door is the ability to create private space. A locked door means choosing vulnerability; an unlocked one means performing for an audience that could arrive at any moment.

YOUR ANSWER

Who can enter someone's private space uninvited?

A private space is only as private as the people who can walk in. Servants, family members, landlords, officials: if others have access, then "alone" is always conditional.

YOUR ANSWER

What surveillance exists?

Surveillance determines how carefully your characters must perform in public. Magical scrying, spy networks, and informants all create different levels of pressure, and different risks if your characters are caught together.

What methods of watching or monitoring people exist in your world?

Think about magical scrying, spy networks, informants, or nothing systematic at all.

YOUR ANSWER

Where can people have truly private conversations?

In a world where privacy is scarce, the locations where characters can speak freely become sacred. These are the places where masks drop, truths emerge, and the relationship can advance beyond what public performance allows.

YOUR ANSWER

What are the consequences of being overheard?

The stakes of privacy shape how carefully characters speak and act. If the wrong person hearing the wrong thing means execution, exile, or scandal, then every whispered word carries enormous weight.

What’s the worst thing that could happen if your characters were overheard together?

WHAT'S THE WORST THING THAT COULD HAPPEN IF YOUR CHARACTERS WERE OVERHEARD TOGETHER?

Design a stolen moment for your characters.
In worlds where privacy is scarce, every stolen moment carries the weight of an entire scene. Think about how your characters would navigate surveillance to create a private interaction, and what the consequences would be if they were caught.

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
Where does the moment happen?	
Who or what are they hiding from?	
What do they do or say?	
How do they cover their tracks?	

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
What would happen if they were caught?	

Servants & Attendants

Do servants exist in your world? How common are they?

Servants witness everything. Their presence shapes what can be said and done, and who knows the household's secrets.

What do servants do, and what do they see?

Servants who dress, bathe, clean, and attend their employers witness the most private moments of their lives. A servant who handles personal items, sleeps nearby, or is present during vulnerable moments is a witness to everything your characters want to hide.

Cooking, cleaning, dressing, attending, managing households. Are they present for private moments? Do they handle personal items? Do they sleep nearby?

What's the relationship between servants and employers?

The nature of the servant-employer bond determines whether servants are allies or threats to your romance. A loyal retainer who becomes a confidant is a very different story element from an ambitious servant who trades secrets for advancement.

Loyal retainers? Interchangeable staff? Family-like? Strictly hierarchical?

Can servants be trusted with secrets?

What motivates a servant's loyalty (or disloyalty) affects whether your characters can ever truly be alone. A servant who becomes a trusted confidant can enable the romance; one who becomes an informant can destroy it.

What motivates their loyalty or disloyalty?

Do your characters have servants?

Think about how servants affect your characters' ability to have private moments, and whether any servants become confidants or threats.

Does your protagonist have servants or attendants? Does your love interest?

Think about how the presence or absence of attendants affects their ability to have private moments.

(Write your answer below)



How do servants affect what your characters can do privately?

The constant presence of others shapes intimacy. What strategies do your characters use to find moments alone, and what happens when those strategies fail?



◆ Checkpoint: Distance, Communication & Privacy

Pause and look at your answers so far. How do your travel times, communication speeds, and privacy levels work together? Do they create consistent obstacles, or does one undercut the others? If your characters can teleport instantly but also can't send a message, ask yourself whether that tension is intentional or a gap you need to resolve. Adjust before moving on.

Daily Life & the Texture of Time

Daily life shapes the sensory world of your story: the quality of light, the temperature of rooms, the smell of a city, what meals look and taste like. These details make your world feel lived-in.

Time & Labour

How much of the day do ordinary people spend on survival tasks?

Food preparation, water collection, heating, cleaning: how does this shape what time is left for anything else?

(Write your answer below)

Who does this labour?

Servants? Women? Lower classes? Everyone? Magical solutions?

How much leisure time does each class have?

HOW MUCH LEISURE TIME DOES EACH CLASS HAVE?

Lighting & Darkness

How do people light their spaces?

Candles, oil lamps, torches, magical light, gas, electricity:

How expensive is lighting?

Can everyone afford to stay up after dark, or is darkness the norm for the poor?

What does nighttime look like in cities, in homes, and in the countryside?

(Write your answer below)

What can and can't be done after dark?

Think about safety, curfews, and what activities require daylight.

YOUR ANSWER

Heating, Cooling & Shelter

♦ **Core: How do people stay warm?**

Fireplaces, central heating, braziers, body heat, magical warmth:

How do people stay cool?

Fans, shade, water, magical cooling, architectural solutions:

Where does fuel for heating come from, and who controls it?

WHERE DOES FUEL FOR HEATING COME FROM, AND WHO CONTROLS IT?

What temperature extremes exist in your world?

Can cold or heat kill? What do people do to survive extremes?

Think about how extremes force people into shared shelter or close quarters.

YOUR ANSWER

Water, Sanitation & Bathing

Bathing technology shapes some of romantasy's most charged scenes. The setting (river, bathhouse, private chamber) determines the kind of vulnerability on display. In pre-industrial worlds, a true bath may be a luxury, making the act itself significant.

♦ Core: How do people get clean water?

Wells, rivers, aqueducts, pumps, magical purification: the answer shapes daily labour, disease risk, and who controls a basic necessity.

Where does drinking water come from, and how far do people travel to get it?

WHERE DOES DRINKING WATER COME FROM, AND HOW FAR DO PEOPLE TRAVEL TO GET IT?

How do people bathe?

Public bathhouses, private baths, rivers/lakes, basins, rarely:

YOUR ANSWER

FREQUENCY

What does bathing look like for your protagonist? For your love interest?

(Write your answer below)

What sanitation exists?

Sewers, chamber pots, outhouses, magical waste disposal:

What are the health implications of your sanitation level?

Disease risk, cleanliness, smell:

YOUR ANSWER

What does your world smell like?

A world without modern sanitation has a rich sensory landscape. Cities smell of woodsmoke, horse, tallow, and river mud. People smell of sweat, leather, and herbs. These baseline scents make your world feel lived-in.

What are the dominant smells of your world: in cities, in homes, in the countryside?

(Write your answer below)

What does your love interest smell like against that background?

Give their scent an in-world justification (herbal wash, scented oils, magical essence) and think about how it makes your protagonist feel.

(Write your answer below)

Food & Drink

Food marks class in visible ways and shared meals negotiate power. A character who has never eaten anything sweet reacts differently to a feast than one who takes it for granted. Every shared meal communicates status, care, and vulnerability.

♦ **Core: Where does food come from, and how does it reach people?**

Markets, farms, foraging, trade caravans, magical agriculture. How food reaches your characters tells you what happens when supply lines break.

Farming? Markets? Trade caravans? Foraging? Magical agriculture?

YOUR ANSWER

How is food preserved?

Salting, smoking, drying, pickling, cold storage, magical preservation:

Fresh food daily? Seasonal eating? Long-term storage possible?

What food is available to the wealthy, to ordinary people, and to the poor?

(Write your answer below)

What does your protagonist typically eat? What does your love interest typically eat?

(Write your answer below)

What would a shared meal reveal about the gap between your characters?

Who hosts, who serves, who speaks, who may leave: think about who would feel out of place.

(Write your answer below)

Timekeeping

How do people tell time, and how precise is it?

Sun position, bells, clocks, magical timekeepers:

Imprecise timekeeping means “meet me at sunset” creates ambiguity that “meet me at 6:15 PM” doesn’t.

Do people schedule precisely, or approximately?

DO PEOPLE SCHEDULE PRECISELY, OR APPROXIMATELY?

◆ Checkpoint: Daily Life & Class

Pause and look at your answers so far. Does the daily life you've described match the technology level you established at the start? If your world is pre-industrial but your characters seem to have easy access to lighting, heating, and fresh food, something may need adjusting. Also check: would a wealthy character and a poor character experience a noticeably different version of daily life, or have you accidentally made things too uniform?

Cross-check: Does the daily routine you've described here match what you established in Culture & Customs (Section 3)? If your culture section describes elaborate morning rituals but your technology section shows no running water, something needs reconciling. Daily life is where culture and technology must agree.

Bodies & Vulnerability

Technology and the body intersect in medicine and reproduction; the body is also where romance lives. How will the injuries and health challenges facing your characters affect them? How will those issues be treated? What will be the emotional ramifications of physical intimacy? These determine some of the most emotionally charged moments in your story. A world where all wounds can be healed removes all of the risk from injury and makes your characters invincible. A world where a fever could result in death is a world of vulnerability and will break open your characters.

Caretaking is such a powerful element of romantasy, for it turns romantic feelings into actions. When a character shows up to stay with another injured character, or hold them, or tend to their injuries, or teach them how to ground themselves, this proves their love in ways that talking can't. In *Fourth Wing*, Violet finds herself in a hospital bed after being wounded during a battle, and Xaden is there beside her. This is a classic

hurt/comfort beat where the act of caring is evidence of attachment. In *From Blood and Ash*, Hawke physically calms Poppy down after she becomes overwhelmed by the emotional response of a crowd, and this act of caring reads as co-regulation in a society where she's unable to openly express herself due to the dangers posed by her abilities. Hawke later gives Poppy part of his own blood to save her life after she's been stabbed, and in doing so he not only heals her but also reveals much about himself and transforms the entire nature of the relationship.

Sophie cares for Benedict in *Bridgerton* while he's suffering from a fever at an isolated cottage, which is the Regency era equivalent of "the only healer within a reasonable distance." Fever is inherently a sensory experience: heat, wet hair, and delirious speech. And fever has a unique ability to cause people to confess things they'd never normally admit to, even though they may say things in a state of delirium that they'd never say while sober. The limited medical capabilities of the time (rest, warmth, broth, constant observation) create an intimate environment because the only places where this can occur are away from the prying eyes of chaperones and social expectations of propriety. Isolated locations like cottages and inns represent a form of low-technology containment.

When writing these types of scenes, keep in mind that medical environments tend to become confession environments. When people are sick or injured, they rely on others for care and support, and this dependence often creates a need for compromise or a need to reveal information that changes everything.

Medicine & Healing

♦ Core: What medical knowledge exists?

Medical technology determines what injuries are survivable and what illnesses are death sentences. The gap between "hurt" and "dying" is where caretaking intimacy lives, and your world's medicine determines how wide that gap is.

CONDITION	TREATMENT AVAILABLE	EFFECTIVENESS
Wounds/injuries		
Infection		

CONDITION	TREATMENT AVAILABLE	EFFECTIVENESS
Common illness		
Serious disease		
Childbirth		
Pain		

Who provides medical care?

The person who heals is in a position of extraordinary intimacy: they see the body vulnerable, they touch without the usual social barriers, they hold knowledge about what hurts. Who provides that care in your world shapes who holds that power.

Physicians, healers, midwives, herbalists, magical healers, family members:

What determines access to medical care?

Unequal access to healing is one of the most emotionally charged technology gaps in romantasy. If one character can afford a magical healer and the other can't, that disparity becomes visible every time someone gets hurt.

Cost? Location? Class? Connections?

Does magical healing exist?

Magical healing can remove stakes from injuries, unless it has limits, costs, or is inaccessible to your characters. The most effective romantasy healing systems give with one hand and take with the other.

Does magical healing exist? How common is it, and what can't it heal?

Think about effectiveness, availability, and cost. The most effective romantasy healing systems give with one hand and take with the other.

(Write your answer below)

What injuries or illnesses are survivable vs. fatal?

Understanding what can and can't be healed helps you write realistic stakes. If everything is survivable, danger loses its weight. If too much is fatal, you lose the caretaking scenes where romance deepens.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Easily treated	
Survivable with care	
Usually fatal	

What chronic conditions exist, and how are they managed?

Chronic illness shapes daily life in ways acute injury doesn't. A character who lives with ongoing health concerns experiences vulnerability differently. It's not a single dramatic moment but a constant reality that the love interest must understand and accommodate.

Contraception & Reproduction

♦ Core: What contraception exists?

In romantasy, contraception technology (or its absence) directly affects intimate scenes and their consequences.

What options your characters have shapes what intimacy means and what risks it carries.

METHOD	EFFECTIVENESS	AVAILABILITY
Herbal/natural		
Barrier methods		
Magical prevention		

Who has access to contraception?

Access to contraception is rarely equal. Class, gender, knowledge, and cost all shape who can control the consequences of intimacy, and who can't.

Available to all? Expensive? Forbidden? Requires specific knowledge? Class-dependent?

What happens if contraception fails or isn't used?

The consequences of unprotected intimacy shape how characters approach physical closeness. Social, legal, and practical consequences all affect the weight of every intimate scene.

Social consequences? Legal consequences? Practical consequences?

Is there pressure on anyone to produce heirs?

Heir pressure is one of romantasy's most powerful engines. It can force marriages, forbid them, or make certain relationships politically explosive. Who faces this pressure changes everything about what love is allowed to look like.

Who faces this pressure and from whom?

Do fertility issues exist?

Infertility or difficulty conceiving adds another layer of vulnerability and stakes to intimate relationships, particularly where heir pressure exists.

Infertility, difficulty conceiving, magical interference:

YOUR ANSWER

Identity & Documentation

You’ve established what can heal your characters and what can hurt them. Now consider what can prove who they are, or let them hide it. Official documents allow for certain possibilities and restrict others. Where documentation is rigidly enforced, there are definitive identities, marriages can be proven, and your history will follow you. Without official documentation, you can reinvent yourself, unions can remain private and no one can verify your true identity. Each option provides potential for romantic engagement, just in vastly different ways.

Gaps in documentation and literacy create some of romantasy’s most intense moments. When Feyre is *Under the Mountain* in *ACOTAR*, she’s put into a situation where she must solve a puzzle with writing on the levers. Feyre can’t read the writing and the danger is created by the “tech gap” she has. Rhysand finds out that Feyre is illiterate and decides to keep it a secret, creating both leverage and protection. Readers and critics have extensively discussed how Feyre’s lack of reading skills were treated, since readers consider tech gaps as moral indicators of a love interest’s behaviour: does he educate, shame, hide, or use her lack of education for his own gain?

Whether a character conceals their identity or reveals it is entirely dependent upon the level of technological advancement of their world. In *The Cruel Prince*, a character uses glamour and vows to sustain their identity. Magical social norms make revealing a character’s identity physical (a kiss, a whisper, a demand) rather than documentary. For *From Blood and Ash*, Hawke maintains his alias through role-based access; while serving as a guard, Hawke can be physically close to Poppy without raising her suspicions, which creates a security system vulnerability that’s used for romance. Lady Whistledown’s anonymous identity in *Bridgerton* is protected by print technology (ink, printers, delivery systems), so a character must reveal their identity through direct confrontation to move the secret from being printed to spoken word. Ask yourself: in your world what maintains the secrecy of a character’s identity and what do you need to break it wide open?

What documentation exists?

DOCUMENT TYPE	WHO KEEPS RECORDS	HOW RELIABLE
Birth records		

DOCUMENT TYPE	WHO KEEPS RECORDS	HOW RELIABLE
Death records		
Marriage records		
Identity documents		
Property records		

How do people prove identity?

How identity is verified determines whether your characters can hide who they are, and what it takes to expose them. A world that relies on personal knowledge is very different from one with magical verification.

Personal knowledge? Documents? Witnesses? Magical verification?

What makes a marriage legally valid and provable?

Marriage documentation affects inheritance, legitimacy, and whether unions can be hidden or denied. What your characters need for a legal marriage, and what happens without it, shapes whether secret unions are possible.

What happens without documentation?

If there's no proof of birth, identity, or marriage, the consequences can be liberating or devastating. A character with no records can reinvent themselves; a character who can't prove their marriage has no legal protection.

If there's no proof of birth, identity, or marriage, what are the consequences?

Can documents be falsified?

Forged documents open possibilities: new identities, secret marriages made official, inconvenient births erased. But the risk of discovery adds its own tension.

How difficult is it? What would it require? What are the risks?

Material Culture

From documents and identity, we move to the physical objects that surround your characters every day. What characters wear, where they live, and how they spend leisure time creates the sensory texture of your world, and all of it communicates class, status, and belonging. These details are often where characters from different backgrounds first notice the gulf between them.

Clothing & Textiles

What materials are clothes made from?

Fabric speaks to wealth, region, and practicality. What your protagonist's clothing communicates before they say a word, and how starkly it contrasts with what the love interest wears, tells the reader everything about the gap between their worlds.

How are clothes made?

How clothes are produced affects how easily your characters can disguise themselves, blend into another class, or replace clothing damaged in action.

Hand-sewn, tailored, mass-produced:

How complicated is getting dressed?

Can people dress themselves, or do they need help? Clothing that requires assistance is a privacy issue, and undressing becomes an act that requires trust.

What does clothing signal about class and status?

Clothing can be a disguise, a mark of belonging, or an insurmountable barrier. When your characters cross class lines, what they're wearing is the first thing that betrays or protects them, and the first thing a love interest notices.

What does your protagonist typically wear? What does your love interest wear? What would each notice first about the other's clothing?

WHAT DOES YOUR PROTAGONIST TYPICALLY WEAR? WHAT DOES YOUR LOVE INTEREST WEAR?
WHAT WOULD EACH NOTICE FIRST ABOUT THE OTHER'S CLOTHING?

Construction & Architecture

Architecture shapes where intimacy is possible. Thick stone walls muffle sound; timber partitions don't. A tower room isolates; an open longhouse exposes. Whether your characters live in a sprawling palace or a single-room dwelling determines what privacy looks like and what "alone together" actually means.

♦ Core: What are buildings made from, and what does that mean for privacy?

Stone castles, timber halls, mud-brick dwellings. Each creates different atmospheres and different levels of sound isolation.

What are the most common building materials in your world? Can your characters be heard through the walls?

WHAT ARE THE MOST COMMON BUILDING MATERIALS IN YOUR WORLD? CAN YOUR CHARACTERS BE HEARD THROUGH THE WALLS?

How tall can buildings be?

Height limits shape cityscapes and the symbolic power of towers. What does it mean when someone lives in the highest room, and who has to climb all those stairs to reach them?

What construction techniques exist?

Construction methods determine what's physically possible in your world, and what rooms, hiding places, and escape routes your characters have access to.

YOUR ANSWER

What architectural features are common?

WHAT ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES ARE COMMON?

What does a typical home look like for different classes?

Housing shapes daily intimacy. A single-room dwelling where a whole family sleeps means no privacy at all; a sprawling estate means characters can avoid each other for days. What your characters live in determines what “alone together” actually means.

CLASS	ROOMS / LAYOUT	WHO SHARES SPACE	WHERE IS PRIVACY POSSIBLE?
Wealthy			
Ordinary			
Poor			

Entertainment & Leisure

What entertainment exists in your world?

Dances, performances, feasts, games, competitions: these are settings where characters interact outside of duty or danger.

YOUR ANSWER

What technology enables entertainment?

The instruments, spaces, and equipment that make entertainment possible also shape where characters gather and what they do together. A ballroom requires musicians; a tournament requires a field. What does your world's entertainment infrastructure look like?

Musical instruments, game equipment, performance spaces:

What technologies are luxuries only the wealthy can afford?

Luxury technologies mark class distinction. What would immediately identify someone as wealthy, or as someone pretending to be? When your characters cross class lines, these are the details that betray or protect them.

What technologies are available to everyone, and what is completely out of reach for the poor?

Inaccessible technology creates invisible barriers. What would a poor character simply never encounter in their normal life, and how would they react when they first experienced it alongside a love interest who takes it for granted?

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Available to everyone	
Affordable for middle class only	

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES IN YOUR WORLD
Exclusive to the wealthy or powerful	

Manufacturing & Production

How are goods made in your world?

Individual artisans, guild workshops, magical fabrication, and early factories all produce very different economies and daily lives. How things are made determines what's available, what's scarce, and what counts as valuable.

Artisan craftwork? Guild workshops? Magical fabrication? Proto-industrial methods?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the most important thing your world manufactures, and who controls its production?

WHAT IS THE MOST IMPORTANT THING YOUR WORLD MANUFACTURES, AND WHO CONTROLS ITS PRODUCTION?

Can magical or technological means mass-produce anything?

Mass production changes scarcity. If enchanted looms can weave faster than human hands, what happens to the weavers? If magical forges produce weapons at scale, who controls the output?

YOUR ANSWER

Energy Sources

What powers your world?

The energy sources available, and who controls them, shape daily life, industry, and the balance of power.

ENERGY SOURCE	WHAT IT POWERS	WHO CONTROLS IT
Human/animal labour		
Water (mills, aqueducts)		
Wind (mills, sailing)		
Fire/fuel (wood, coal, peat)		

ENERGY SOURCE	WHAT IT POWERS	WHO CONTROLS IT
Magical energy		
Other		

What happens when the primary energy source fails or is cut off?

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN THE PRIMARY ENERGY SOURCE FAILS OR IS CUT OFF?

Is energy access equal, or does it follow class and geographic lines?

IS ENERGY ACCESS EQUAL, OR DOES IT FOLLOW CLASS AND GEOGRAPHIC LINES?

Weapons & Conflict

Daily life tells you what's normal for your characters. Now consider what disrupts that normal. Weapons shape who holds physical power and who depends on someone else for protection. The availability of weapons, who is allowed to carry them, and what training exists all determine the physical stakes your characters face.

What weapons exist?

Available weapons shape both conflict and protection. What your protagonist can fight with, or against, determines the physical stakes of every dangerous scene and how much they depend on the person beside them.

What weapons exist in your world?

List examples of melee, ranged, siege, and magical weapons.

(Write your answer below)

What armour exists?

Armour protects but also constrains. A character in full plate is safe but untouchable; a character in leather is vulnerable but mobile. The trade-off between protection and accessibility is a physical metaphor for the emotional walls your characters build.

What's the most advanced military technology?

The cutting edge of warfare reveals what powers fear most. What weapons or defences give decisive advantage, and how does that shape the danger your characters face?

Who has access to weapons?

A character who's forbidden from carrying weapons faces danger differently than one who is armed, and depends differently on the person beside them. Weapon restrictions also shape training dynamics: if your protagonist isn't allowed to train, learning in secret becomes an act of rebellion and trust.

Restricted to military/nobility? Commonly owned? Forbidden to certain groups?

Does weapons training exist, and who has access to it?

Who trains, where, and under what conditions? Is training restricted by class, gender, or institution?

Training and sparring scenes carry natural romantic tension: physical proximity, sanctioned touch, one person in authority over another's body, all under the cover of "practice." If your characters train together, that dynamic can do double duty.

Is there a training or sparring dynamic between your characters?

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
Who trains whom, or are they equals?	
What skill is being taught?	
What creates the tension?	



◆ Checkpoint: Bodies, Weapons & Stakes

Pause and look at your answers so far. Are your medical capabilities and your weapon technology telling the same story? If healing magic can fix almost anything but you also want injury to carry real weight, you may need to add limits to what healing can do. Check that contraception, medicine, and weapons all support the level of physical stakes your romance needs.

Knowledge & Education

Weapons determine physical power. Knowledge determines every other kind. Who has access to information and who doesn't, shapes power dynamics in romance just as much as wealth or title. The ability to read when others can't is a particularly significant form of power. In a world where books are hard to come by, the value of giving one as a gift is based on the fact that books are scarce. And the act of teaching someone to read, sharing knowledge, or revealing a hidden library is an act of trust and intimacy that technology level makes possible.

What do people write on?

Writing surfaces affect who can communicate in writing and how portable that communication is. A love letter carved into wax is a very different object from one inked on paper, and the material itself signals what the writer had access to.

Paper, parchment, clay, wax tablets, magical surfaces:

What do people write with?

Writing tools affect who can communicate in writing and how portable that communication is. A quill and ink require a desk; a charcoal stick works anywhere. What your characters have access to shapes what they can say and where they can say it.

YOUR ANSWER

How are books made?

How books are produced determines how scarce they are, and scarcity changes their meaning. In a world where every book is hand-copied, giving one is an act of extraordinary generosity and intimacy.

Hand-copied, printed, magically reproduced:

How expensive and rare are books?

The scarcity of books affects who has access to knowledge, and how precious a single volume might be as a gift, an inheritance, or a sign of trust between two people who share what others can't access.

Who can access education?

Education access shapes the power dynamic between your characters more than almost any other technology. If one can read and the other can't, if one has been trained and the other hasn't, that gap becomes a source of dependency, shame, or intimacy. Teaching someone is an act of trust; being taught is an act of vulnerability.

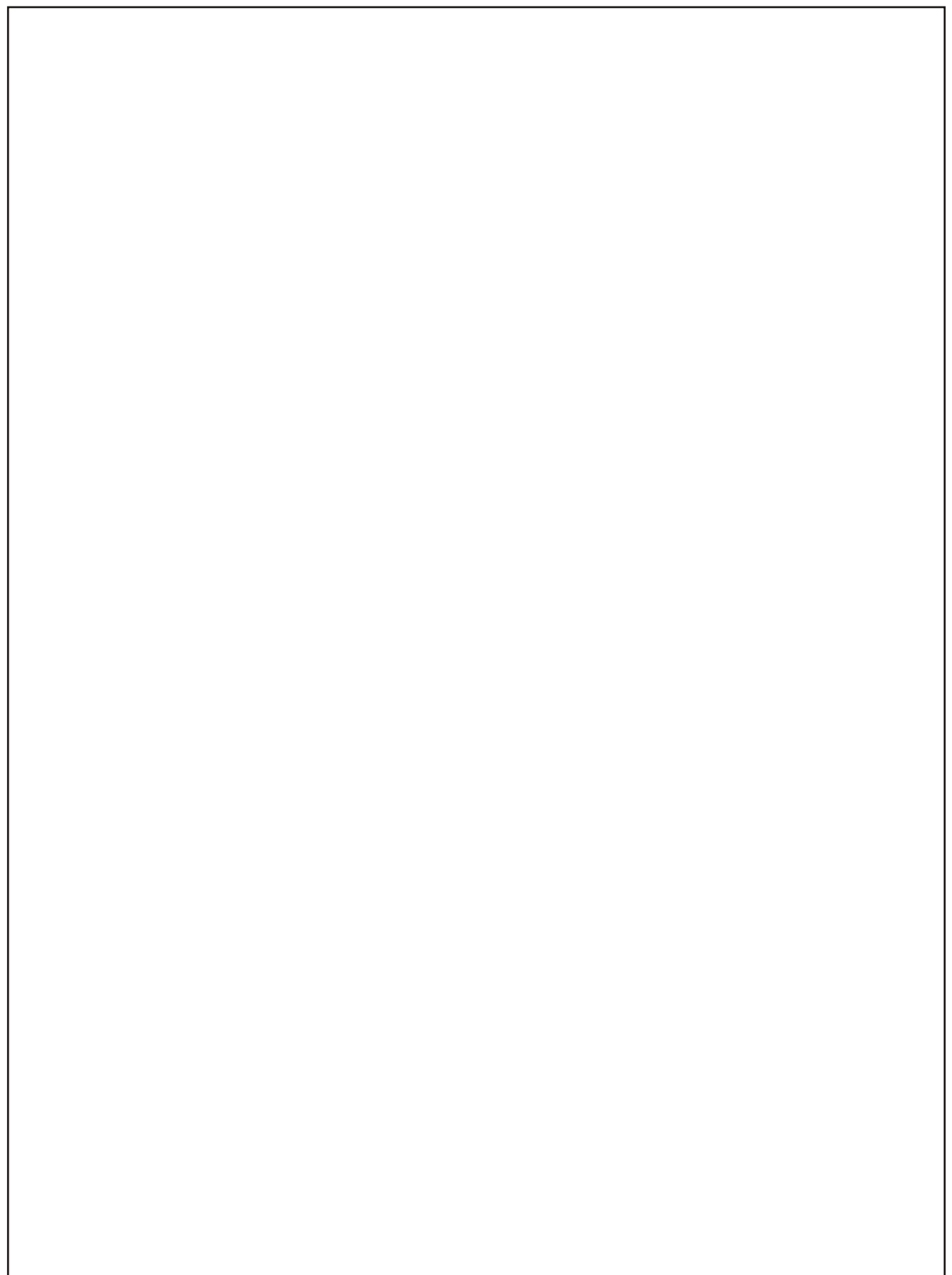
Universal? Class-restricted? Gender-restricted? If your characters come from different education levels, how does that gap affect their dynamic? Does one teach the other, and what does that teaching look like?

Does knowledge create a power dynamic between your characters?

When one character can read and the other can't, when one has access to information the other is denied, the knowledge gap becomes a source of dependency, shame, or intimacy. Teaching someone is an act of trust. Withholding knowledge is an act of control.

Does either character have knowledge the other lacks? How does the gap affect their dynamic?

*Think about whether one teaches the other, and whether the gap creates dependency, shame, wonder, or trust.
(Write your answer below)*



Magic & Technology Integration

If your world has magic, it doesn't exist in a vacuum. It interacts with technology, replaces it, enhances it, or conflicts with it. The key question for romance isn't "how does magic work?" but "who has access to magical solutions and who doesn't?" That asymmetry drives character dynamics.

Does magic replace certain technologies?

When magic fills a need that technology would otherwise serve, it changes who has access to solutions.

If magical heating replaces fireplaces, then characters without magic are left in the cold, literally and figuratively.

What technology doesn't exist because magic fills the need:

Does magic enhance technology?

Enchanted items and magitech create a world where some tools are more powerful than they should be, and access to those enhanced tools becomes another axis of inequality between your characters.

Enchanted items, magitech:

Do magic and technology conflict?

If magic interferes with technology or vice versa, your characters may have to choose between magical and technological solutions, and that choice reveals what they value and who they trust.

Does magic interfere with technology or vice versa?

Who has access to magical vs. technological solutions?

Magic and technology may solve similar problems differently. Which solution is available to your protagonist, and which is beyond reach? The gap between magical and mundane solutions is often the gap between your characters' worlds.

How does the magic/technology divide affect your characters' relationship?

When one character has access to magical solutions and the other relies on slower, harder alternatives, the gap creates dependency, resentment, or wonder. This asymmetry is fuel for romantic tension.

What magical solution does one character have that the other doesn't?

Think about how the character without magic solves the same problem, and whether the divide creates dependency, resentment, wonder, or something else.

(Write your answer below)

Lost or Forbidden Technology

Did past civilisations have technology now lost?

Lost technology creates mystery and possibility. What ancient wonders might your characters discover or seek, and could the quest to find them bring your characters together or drive them apart?

What was lost, why, and could it be rediscovered?

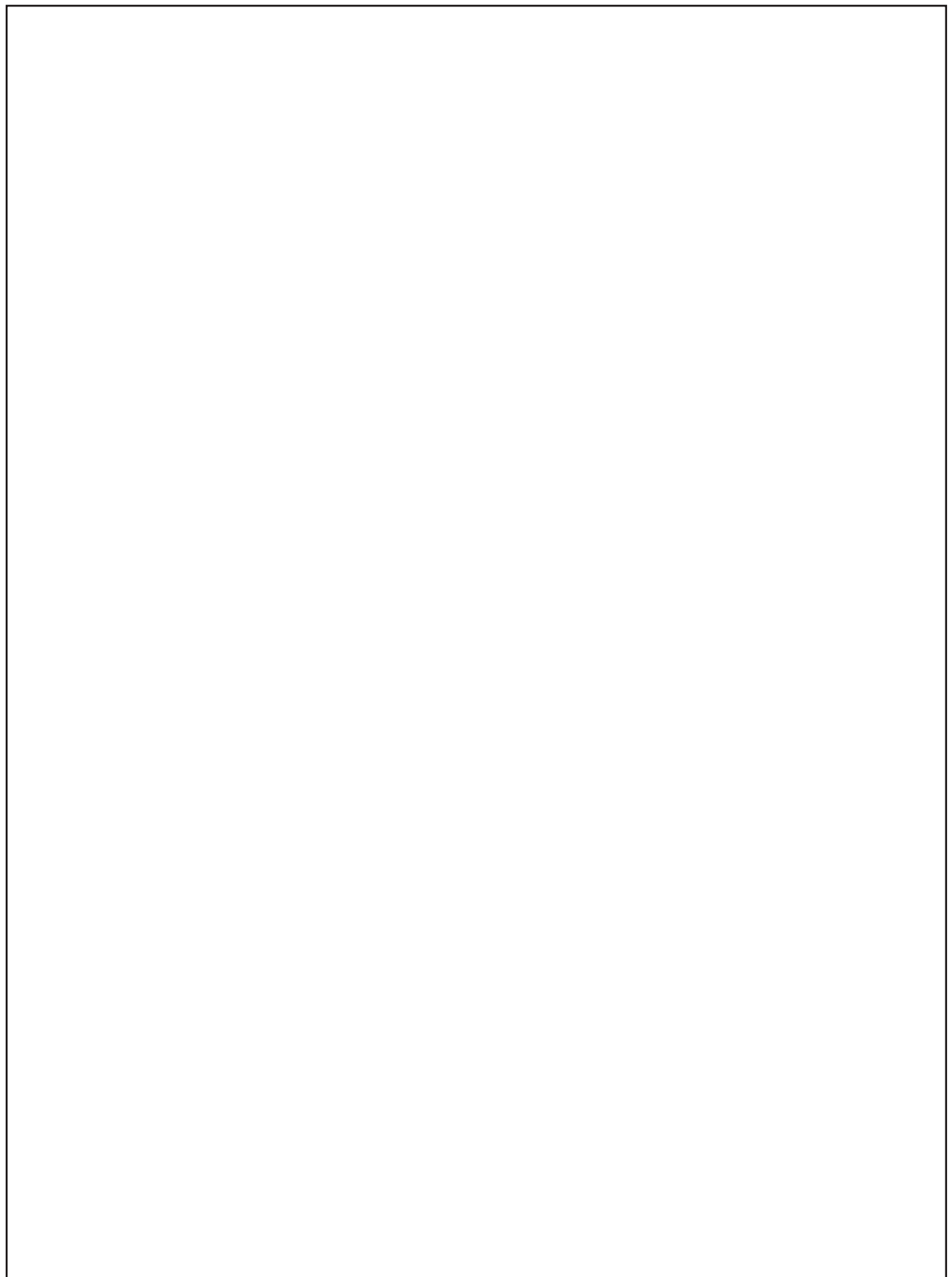
(Write your answer below)

Is any technology restricted or forbidden?

Forbidden technology creates temptation and danger. A character willing to risk punishment to access forbidden knowledge or tools reveals how much they're willing to sacrifice, and a shared secret about forbidden technology binds characters together.

What technology is restricted or forbidden? Who restricts it, and what happens if someone uses it anyway?

(Write your answer below)



Technology & Your Characters: Synthesis

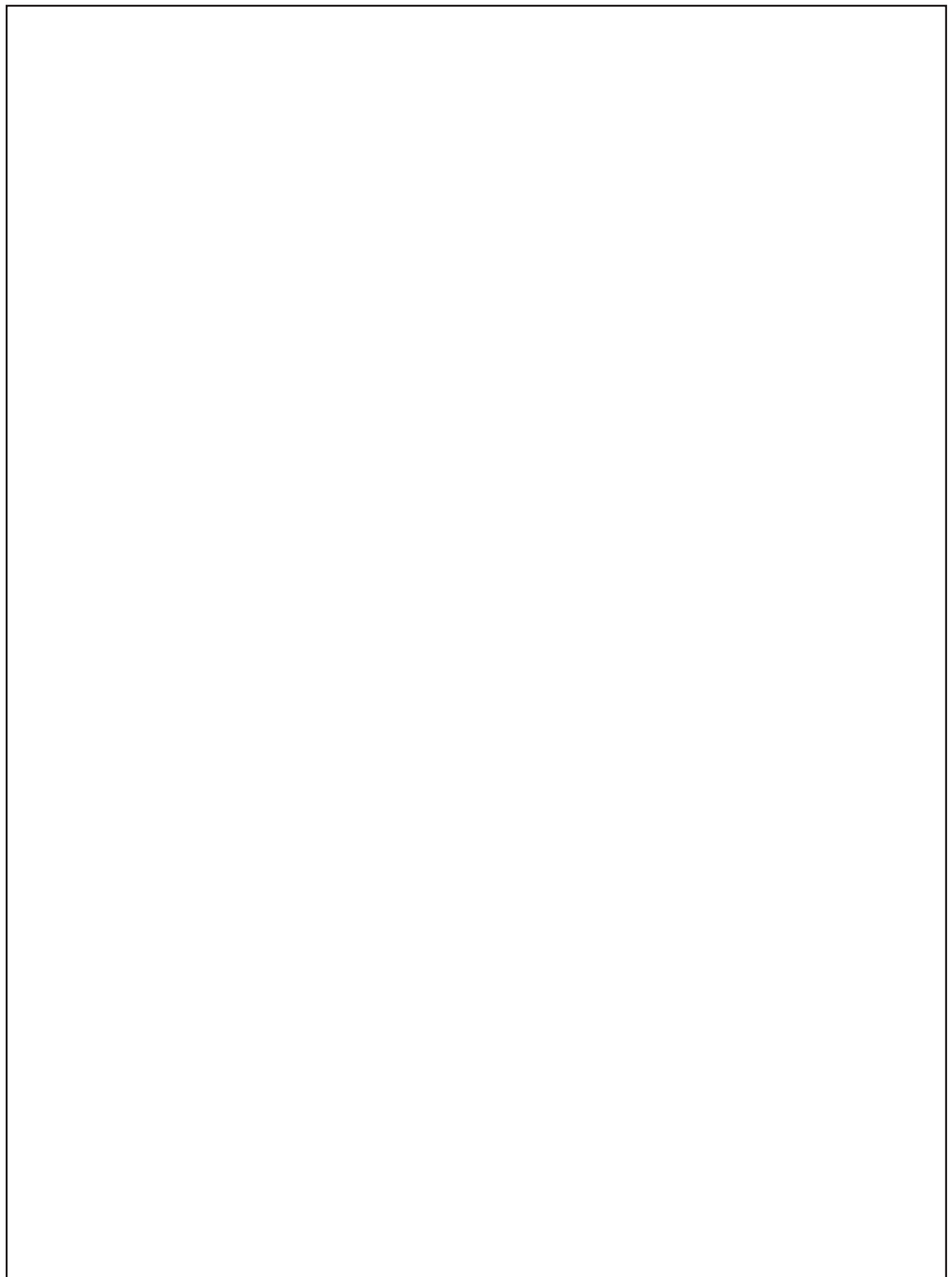
You've covered the systems. Now pull together your answers from earlier sections into one view. This is your technology profile for these two specific people!

CATEGORY	YOUR PROTAGONIST	YOUR LOVE INTEREST
Travel: how do they get around?		
Communication: how do they reach each other when apart?		
Privacy: where can they be unobserved?		
Servants/attendants: who witnesses their private life?		
Medical access: what healing is available to them?		
Contraception: what's available and what are the risks?		

CATEGORY	YOUR PROTAGONIST	YOUR LOVE INTEREST
Documentation: could they marry secretly?		
Biggest technology advantage over the other		
Biggest technology disadvantage compared to the other		

What is the single biggest technology gap between your characters, and how does it shape their dynamic?

(Write your answer below)



The Emotional Layer: Apply the Constraint Engine

Now that you've built the physical, social, and technological reality of your world, it's time to return to the Constraint Engine principle from the opening of this section. You now know what technology exists, who has access to it, and how it shapes daily life. That means you can map the romantic consequences with specificity rather than guessing.

What are the key technology constraints in your world?

The Constraint Engine principle says every technology choice either adds or removes an obstacle between your characters. The most powerful choices do both: they force proximity (containment) while creating emotional intensity (conversion). Map your world's biggest technology constraints and identify what each one does to your romance.

TECHNOLOGY CONSTRAINT	CONTAINMENT (HOW IT FORCES PROXIMITY)	CONVERSION (HOW PROXIMITY BECOMES EMOTIONAL)	ASYMMETRY (DOES ONE CHARACTER HAVE AN ADVANTAGE?)
<i>Dragon bond requires physical proximity (Fourth Wing)</i>	<i>Riders must stay within range of each other's dragons</i>	<i>Forced closeness lets suspicion become reluctant trust</i>	<i>Xaden understands the bond; Violet is learning</i>

How does your world rate on each of the five romantic channels?

For each channel, note whether your world leans low-tech or high-tech and what that creates for your characters.

CHANNEL	LOW OR HIGH IN YOUR WORLD?	WHAT IT CREATES FOR YOUR ROMANCE
Distance		
Communication		
Privacy		
Vulnerability		
Identity		

What does micro-intimacy look like for your characters?

The strongest romantic technology constraints produce touch that must be hidden, words that must be delayed, and care that must be given without claiming ownership. The interruption keeps the barrier intact while feeding the relationship. If your characters can only touch for three seconds before someone rounds the corner, those three seconds carry the weight of an entire scene.

MOMENT	WHAT THE MICRO-INTIMACY LOOKS LIKE	WHAT INTERRUPTS IT	WHAT IT REVEALS ABOUT THE RELATIONSHIP
<i>Jude and Cardan's kiss (The Cruel Prince)</i>	<i>A single kiss, immediately re-contained</i>	<i>Exposure is too dangerous at court</i>	<i>Desire exists but must be suppressed</i>

Integration Check

QUESTION	CONNECTION	EXAMPLE
How does geography affect technology? (Section 1)	Mountains, rivers, and climate shape what tech is possible and where it reaches	Mountain passes close in winter, cutting off communication for months
What technology drives the economy? (Section 4)	Key industries depend on specific technologies	Enchanted forges create the kingdom's wealth, and its military advantage
How does government use or restrict technology? (Section 5)	Governments control access to create power imbalances	Only licensed mages may operate mirror-gates; unlicensed use is treason
How does technology affect different classes? (Section 5)	Technology access maps onto class structure	Nobles have magical heating; commoners burn peat and share beds for warmth
How does magic interact with technology? (Magic System)	Magic may replace, enhance, or conflict with technology	Healing magic makes surgery unnecessary, but only for those who can afford a healer

Quick Reference: Technology Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE
Overall tech level		Medieval with magical enhancements
Travel speed (between key locations)		Capital to border: 3 weeks by horse, instant by mirror-gate (royal only)
Communication speed		Letters: 5 days between cities; bonded items: instant but rare
Communication security		Letters can be intercepted; magical comms private but traceable

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE
Privacy level		Low: thin walls, servants present, court surveillance
Servant presence		Protagonist has none; love interest has three attendants always present
Medical capabilities		Healing magic exists but can't cure poison or illness
Contraception availability		Herbal methods known but unreliable; magical prevention expensive
Documentation requirements		Marriage requires witnesses and temple record; births unrecorded in rural areas
Technology gap between characters		She's never seen enchanted light; he's never cooked his own food

Final Thought: Make It Personal

You've built the systems. Now break them, for your characters specifically. The most memorable romantasy technology moments aren't about the world's rules in the abstract. They're about the moment your character realises they can't get a message sent in time. The moment your love interest discovers he can't lock the door. The moment a wound won't heal and someone has to stay.

Technology isn't about gadgets. It's about what your world makes easy and what it makes hard. The best constraint is the one your characters feel in their bones.

What's Next? You've mapped what your world makes easy and what it makes hard. Next, move to **Language & Communication (Section 10)** to explore how your characters actually speak to each other: what languages exist, who can understand whom, and how barriers of language create their own kind of intimacy and

misunderstanding. The technology you've built here shapes what communication tools are available; Language & Communication explores what your characters do with them.